



SELLING ON EBAY

Launch playbook for the small-goods line — woven baskets, rugs, placemats, pottery, and talavera

Quality Firewood & Materials • July 16, 2026

Fee figures in this playbook are current as of July 2026. eBay adjusts fees two to three times a year — we re-verify against eBay's published fee page before relying on any number here for pricing decisions.

Why eBay for This Catalog

eBay puts our small goods in front of the largest audience of home-décor and folk-art buyers in the country without waiting for anyone to find our own store. Talavera and hand-woven goods have genuine collector demand there, the marketplace handles payment processing and sales tax for us, and every listing doubles as advertising for the yard. It is a second channel beside our online store — same inventory, same item codes, same shipping bench — and the discipline that keeps two channels honest is written into this playbook.

Setup — Zero to First Listing

In dependency order. The only durations quoted are eBay's own stated windows.

- 1. Gather the paperwork.** EIN, exact legal name (Quality Firewood & Materials, Inc.), business address and phone, the officer's personal identification details, and the business checking account and routing numbers. Everything downstream needs these.
- 2. Register a BUSINESS account.** At [ebay.com/register](https://www.ebay.com/register), take the business path from the start — converting a personal account later is a support ticket and an approval wait. eBay runs bank-style identity verification on the company and its officer.
- 3. Link the payout bank account.** Payouts only go to an account whose name matches the registered entity. If eBay verifies by micro-deposit, that is a 1–2 business day step (eBay's stated window).
- 4. Set the account-level policies.** Payout schedule; business policies for Shipping, Returns (30-day returns accepted), and Payment; handling time (2 business days — see Shipping); and opt in to eBay International Shipping while we are in the settings.
- 5. Skip the store subscription for now.** Below the Basic tier a store buys us nothing on fees, and 250 free listings a month cover the start. We revisit when the live catalog passes ~250 items or eBay sales pass ~\$2,400 a month — that is where Basic starts paying for itself.
- 6. Set up the pack station.** Scale and tape measure at the station; box and bubble stock on hand, including double-box sizes for pottery. Weigh and measure a boxed example of each item class — the box, not the bare item.



- 7. Do the price research.** Search each item type on eBay and filter to SOLD listings — sold prices are reality, active listings are wishes. Build the price sheet with the all-in eBay cost (~15–17% of the gross) and real packaging cost baked in.
- 8. Assign item codes BEFORE anything lists.** One code per item, the same code in eBay’s Custom label field, in Shopify, and on our paper. This single habit is what keeps two channels from selling the same one-of-a-kind piece twice.
- 9. Photograph properly.** Up to 24 photos are free — use them. 1600px or better for zoom; first photo on a clean background; then angles, a scale shot with a tape measure, texture close-ups, and the base or maker’s mark on talavera.
- 10. Create the first listings.** Fixed price, Good ’Til Cancelled, every item specific filled in, the item code in Custom label. Start with a modest batch — new accounts carry selling limits that rise with history.
- 11. Turn on Promoted Listings General at 2–3%.** New listings have no sales history, and a small ad rate substitutes for rank while history accrues. Ignore eBay’s suggested rate — it runs high.
- 12. Ship the first sales flawlessly.** eBay-purchased labels, inside the handling window, every time. New-seller payouts are held at first — funds release fastest (2 days after delivery confirmation) when eBay’s own labels provide the tracking.
- 13. Run the daily rhythm from order one.** Orders queue every open morning, messages inside 24 hours, and the cross-channel delist ritual on every sale of a one-of-a-kind piece.

What eBay Costs

eBay’s final value fee is charged on the WHOLE order — item price plus buyer-paid shipping plus the sales tax eBay collects — and payment processing is included in it. For Home & Garden as of July 2026: 13.6% plus \$0.40 per order with no store subscription; 12.7% plus \$0.40 with a Basic store. Two of our actual price points, worked through:

	Basket \$39 + \$12 shipping	Rug \$169 + \$12 shipping
Order total eBay fees on	\$51.00	\$181.00
Fees, no store (13.6% + \$0.40)	\$7.34	\$25.02
Net to us, no store	\$43.66	\$155.98
Fees, Basic store (12.7% + \$0.40)	\$6.88	\$23.39
Net to us, Basic store	\$44.12	\$157.61
Basic store saves	\$0.46	\$1.63

Nets are before the shipping label (roughly \$8–13 at these weights through eBay’s discounted labels — the buyer’s \$12 roughly covers it) and before promoted-listings spend at 2–3%. The planning number for the price sheet: all-in eBay cost runs about 15–17% of the gross with light promotion, plus real packaging cost. A Basic store (\$21.95/month on the annual rate) does not pay for itself until roughly \$2,400 a month in eBay sales or 250+ live listings — we start without one.



Watch-outs: the Starter store tier carries no fee discount at all — skip it. Good 'Til Cancelled listings renew monthly and each renewal consumes a free listing from the monthly allotment. And an account that falls Below Standard pays a 6-point fee surcharge — the ten rules at the end exist to make that impossible.

Getting Paid — the New-Seller Holds

eBay holds a new seller's money while a track record builds. Funds release about 2 days after delivery confirmation when the package ships on an eBay label, 7 days with a third-party label, and up to 30 days with no tracking at all. The first month of sales will arrive slowly no matter what we do — but eBay labels with automatic tracking are what shorten it. Normal payouts thereafter: about 1–2 business days for funds to clear plus 1–3 for the bank transfer.

Listing the Goods

- **Titles are keyword stacks, not sentences.** Material + item type + style + color + size, using all 80 characters: "Talavera Mexican Pottery Planter Hand Painted Blue 8 in Flower Pot Folk Art."
- **Fill every item specific.** Brand (Handmade/Unbranded), material, style, room, color, dimensions — the specifics feed the filters buyers click, and a listing with empty specifics is invisible to them.
- **Photos win the click.** Up to 24 free — clean background first photo, angles, a scale shot with a tape measure, texture close-ups, the maker's mark on talavera. 1600px or larger so zoom works.
- **Fixed price for everything; one listing per identical item group.** Auctions are for scarcity, not \$39 baskets. Twenty identical baskets = ONE listing with quantity 20 — its accumulated sales compound its search rank, and duplicate listings violate policy.
- **Price from sold listings.** Filter search to Sold Items and price inside that band — active listings are asking prices, sold listings are the market.
- **Beat the zero-feedback trust gap.** 30-day returns, fast handling, free shipping on the light flat goods, honest condition notes, a few early modest sales for the first feedbacks, and Promoted Listings General at 2–3% from day one.

Shipping

- **Buy labels inside eBay.** Commercial rates run well below counter prices, and tracking uploads automatically — which feeds the metrics AND releases held payouts fastest. USPS Ground Advantage is the workhorse for 1–15 lb; UPS Ground takes over for heavy or bulky boxes like rugs.
- **Rate strategy by item class.** CALCULATED shipping for pottery and rugs (the buyer pays by distance — we can never lose money on a far ZIP code). FREE shipping baked into the price for placemats and napkin rings — it boosts search placement. Weigh and measure the BOX before listing, never after the sale.



- **Double-box all pottery and talavera.** Wrap with two inches of cushion, float that box inside a second with two more inches on all six sides. Budget \$2–4 of packaging into the price. A single-boxed pot is a refund, a defect, and a bad review traveling together.
- **Handling time: promise 2 business days.** One-day handling ranks better, but the yard is dark Sundays and Tuesdays — we promise 2, deliver in 1 when we can, and never miss. The clock stops at the carrier's ACCEPTANCE SCAN, not when the box leaves our hands.
- **Opt in to eBay International Shipping.** We ship international orders to eBay's domestic hub with a normal label; eBay handles customs, duties, the overseas leg, and returns — and once the hub accepts the box, we are protected from loss, damage, and chargebacks. Near-zero-risk reach into the talavera collector market.

Taxes, Briefly

eBay is a marketplace facilitator: it calculates, collects, and remits buyers' sales tax automatically. On the New Mexico side, marketplace-facilitated receipts still get reported on the GRT return and then deducted — so the bookkeeping keeps eBay sales in their own income account, and the CPA gets eBay's annual sales report at year-end. The federal 1099-K threshold is back to \$20,000 AND 200 transactions; as a business account it would report under the company EIN, and it reports gross — income is booked from the transaction reports, not the form.

Living With the Shopify Store

The one disaster to prevent: a one-of-a-kind piece sells on Shopify tonight and sells again on eBay tomorrow morning. eBay counts an out-of-stock cancellation as a DEFECT, and a handful of defects at our volume is enough to drop the account a tier and raise our fees 6 points. Three habits prevent it entirely:

- **One item code everywhere.** The same code in eBay's Custom label field, in Shopify, and on the paper. Five seconds to check any listing against the shelf.
- **The same-day delist ritual.** When a one-of-a-kind piece sells on either channel, ending its twin listing on the other channel is part of processing the order — before the box is packed, not after.
- **Split the count on multiples.** For identical items, either split the physical stock between channels or hold a shared count and update both channels at the end of each day.

Connector software becomes worth it around 5–10 orders a day, or after the first oversell — whichever comes first. Until then, a disciplined human beats a misconfigured app.

The Weekly Rhythm and the Numbers eBay Grades Us On

Daily, every open morning (20–30 minutes at our volume): open the Seller Hub Orders queue; ship everything inside its handling window; answer every buyer message within 24 hours; check the Returns tab and respond



same day. Weekly: glance at the Seller Level dashboard and the promoted-listings spend. Monthly: eBay grades every account on the 20th — we look on the 19th.

Metric	Trouble starts at	Top Rated needs
Transaction defect rate	over 2%	0.5% or less
Cases closed without our resolution	over 0.3% (or 2 cases)	0.3% or less
Late shipment rate	hurts search rank	3% or less
Valid tracking uploaded on time	hurts search rank	95% or more

What actually gets new sellers suspended: cancelling for out-of-stock, ignoring return requests until eBay steps in, shipping without tracking, and working around the new-account selling limits. Every one of them is a process failure — and the fulfillment SOP plus the ten rules below close every door.

The Ten Rules

Posted at the pack station, reviewed at the weekly management meeting.

1. Never cancel for "out of stock." A one-of-a-kind piece that sells anywhere is ended on the other channel the same business day.
2. Every package ships with tracking on an eBay-purchased label. No exceptions.
3. Ship inside the promised handling window, every time.
4. Never let a return or item-not-received request sit 3 business days unanswered — if eBay steps in, that is the worst mark we can take.
5. One item code, everywhere: eBay, Shopify, and the paper.
6. Double-box all pottery and talavera — two inches of cushion in both boxes.
7. Describe flaws before the buyer finds them. Honest condition notes and measurements in every listing.
8. Check the Orders queue every open morning; answer messages within 24 hours.
9. Price from SOLD listings, not asking prices; hold the ad rate at 2–3% and review the spend monthly.
10. Look at the Seller Level dashboard on the 19th of every month — eBay grades us on the 20th.